In fact, Sarabhai had been inviting Dhawan to join the space programme and the prime minister did not look further in search of Sarabhai's successor. But since Dhawan, then the director of Indian Institute of Sciences, Bangalore was abroad, the government appointed M G K Menon as the interim chairman.

M G K Menon, who took over the reins of Tata Institute of Fundamental Research at the age of thirty-eight from Homi J Bhabha, on the latter's death in a plane crash in Mont Blanc in 1966, and remained the chairman for nine months, till September 1972. Dhawan put one condition before accepting the ISRO mantle. He would not move out of Bangalore. If Mohammed won't go to the mountain, the mountain must come to him. That is how ISRO came to be headquartered in Bangalore.

'What are you pondering over?' Rao's voice woke me up from my thoughts.

I took the resignation letter from my pocket.

'Now that the launch is over, I am quitting,' I said, handing over the letter.

'But the launch is a failure,' said Rao.

'My part worked well, the second stage.'

Rao considered this for a moment. Both of us knew that the argument was just technical, the real issue—the LPSC succession was still hanging fire.

He countered me.

'You are also the project director of the fourth stage. We haven't yet seen its success.'

He tore my resignation letter and threw it in the bin. It was the second time this had happened; the first time it was Dhawan flinging my resignation after the failure of the ground test of the three-tonne engine at Sriharikota in 1973.

'Get back to work,' Rao said in his usual soft voice. 'Fly the PSLV successfully and do whatever you want.'

I knew Rao was again buying time, keeping the LPSC succession plan in abeyance. Nevertheless, I thought I should be part of the PSLV success,